

# The Hawks Are Finally Looking Real

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## Executive Summary

Atlanta has spent most of this season bouncing between two familiar tiers: genuinely interesting and overtly frustrating. That is what makes this stretch stand out. The Hawks are in the middle of their most convincing run of the year, stacking wins in a way that feels more complete than the flashes they showed earlier.

Atlanta has sustained this long enough for it to matter, and it has come with real structural improvement. The offense has featured multiple creators instead of relying on a single engine. The defense has been more connected possession-to-possession. The roster looks like it actually fits.

This is one of the best runs the franchise has had in years, and it feels a lot more stable than what they showed for most of the season.

That said, context still matters. The full-season sample still points to volatility, and some of this level is being supported by shotmaking that is unlikely to fully hold. A tougher stretch is coming, and it should give a clearer answer as to how real this version of the Hawks is.

Still, the Hawks' young core has given plenty to be excited about this season and beyond.

## Historic Context

Table 1: Longest Winning Streaks in Hawks Franchise History

| Rank         | Wins      | Season          | Span                    |
|--------------|-----------|-----------------|-------------------------|
| 1st          | 19        | 2014-15         | Dec 27 – Feb 2          |
| 2nd          | 14        | 1993-94         | Nov 16 – Dec 16         |
| 3rd          | 12        | 1968-69         | Dec 8 – Jan 4           |
| <b>T-4th</b> | <b>11</b> | <b>2025-26*</b> | <b>Feb 22 – Present</b> |
| T-4th        | 11        | 1997-98         | Oct 31 – Nov 20         |

\* = active streak

It's been over a decade since a Hawks team has put together a stretch like this.

## League Context

Table 2: Longest Active Winning Streaks

| Rank     | Team       | Streak    |
|----------|------------|-----------|
| <b>1</b> | <b>ATL</b> | <b>11</b> |
| 2        | OKC        | 10        |
| 3        | LAL        | 8         |

Table 3: Longest Winning Streaks This Season

| Rank         | Team        | Streak    | Active   |
|--------------|-------------|-----------|----------|
| 1st          | OKC         | 16        |          |
| 2nd          | DET         | 13        |          |
| T-3rd        | SAS         | 11        |          |
| <b>T-3rd</b> | <b>ATL*</b> | <b>11</b> | <b>*</b> |
| 4th          | OKC*        | 10        | *        |

\* = active streak

The Hawks currently have the longest winning streak in the league, with a pair of streaking teams out West close behind. Over the course of the season, they've put together one of the longer runs anyone's had.

## Seeding Context

Table 4: Eastern Conference Shift During Atlanta's Run

| Team       | Before       | Now          |
|------------|--------------|--------------|
| DET        | 42-13        | 49-19        |
| BOS        | 36-19        | 46-23        |
| CLE        | 36-21        | 42-27        |
| NYK        | 36-21        | 45-25        |
| TOR        | 33-23        | 39-29        |
| PHI        | 30-26        | 37-32        |
| MIA        | 31-27        | 38-31        |
| ORL        | 29-26        | 38-30        |
| <b>ATL</b> | <b>27-31</b> | <b>38-31</b> |
| CHO        | 26-31        | 35-34        |

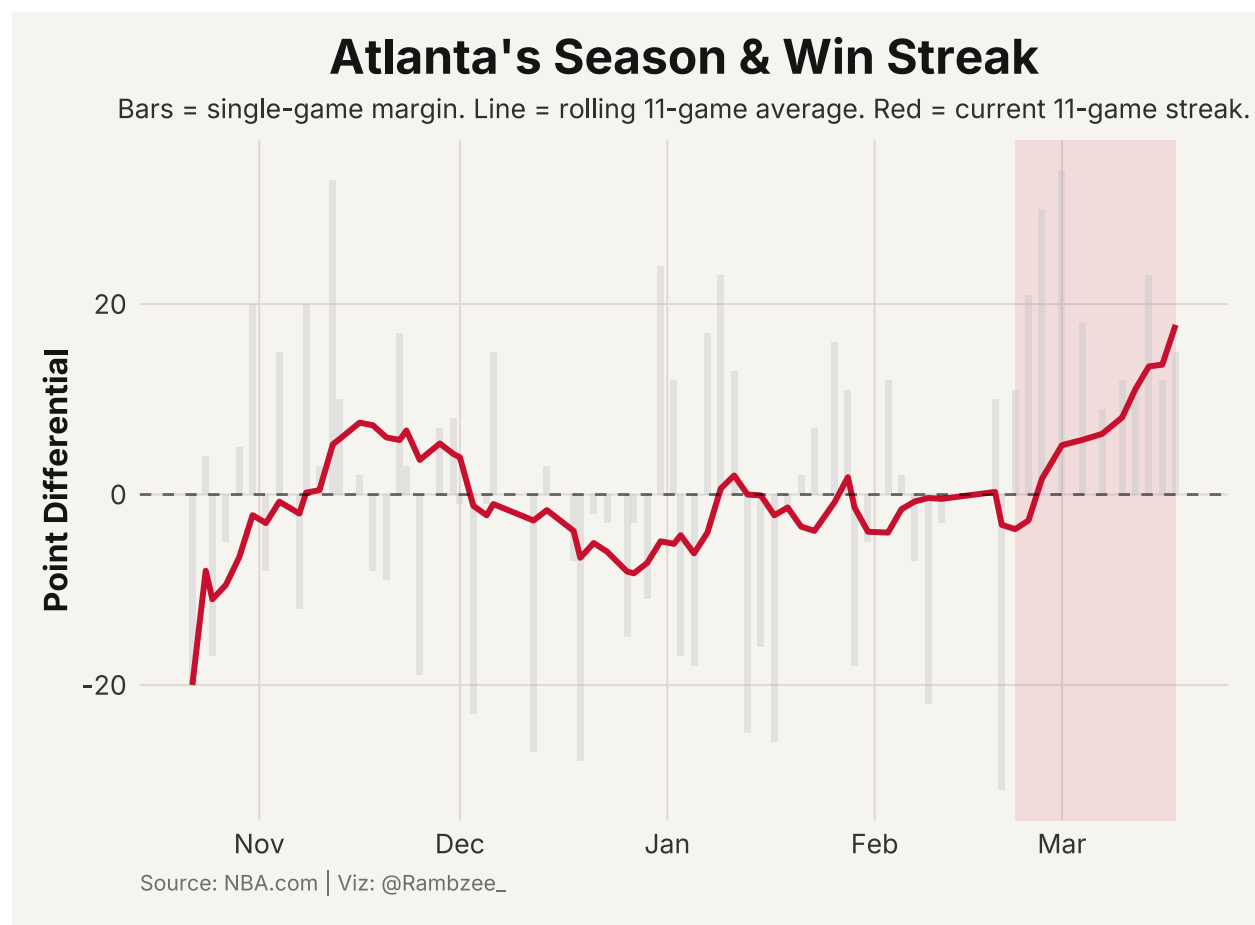
Atlanta was 27–31 and near the bottom of the East. Now they're 38–31 and right in the middle of the playoff race.

## Team Baseline

Table 5: Season vs recent form (team game logs)

| window          | GP | W  | L  | PTS   | OPPPTS | MOV  |
|-----------------|----|----|----|-------|--------|------|
| <b>First 58</b> | 58 | 27 | 31 | 116.9 | 118.6  | -1.6 |
| <b>Last 11</b>  | 11 | 11 | 0  | 124.0 | 106.2  | 17.8 |
| <b>Season</b>   | 69 | 38 | 31 | 118.1 | 116.6  | 1.5  |

Eleven straight wins doesn't happen by accident. Atlanta has gone from being outscored by 1.6 points per game through its first 58 to winning by nearly 18 per game during the streak, all while holding teams to just 106 a night, well below the roughly 115-point league average.



This is where the season starts to make more sense. Atlanta has had its share of ups and downs, with stretches where things slipped. Lately, though, when they play well, it's not just the offense carrying them. The defense has been good enough to hold things together, which is why these wins have started to stack.

## League Context (Last 11 Games)

Table 6: League context over the last 11 games. Relative values are vs league average in the same window.

| team_name     | GP | W  | L | NetRtg | rel_netrtg | netrtg_rank | ORtg  | rel_ortg | ortg_rank | DRtg | rel_drtg | drtg_rank |
|---------------|----|----|---|--------|------------|-------------|-------|----------|-----------|------|----------|-----------|
| Atlanta Hawks | 11 | 11 | 0 | 16.9   | +16.7      | 1           | 119.9 | +6.8     | 2         | 103  | -9.8     | 2         |

Table 7: Top 10 offenses over the last 11 games

| Rk | Team | W-L  | ORtg  | Rel ORtg |
|----|------|------|-------|----------|
| 1  | LAL  | 10-1 | 120.0 | +6.9     |
| 2  | ATL  | 11-0 | 119.9 | +6.8     |
| 3  | SAS  | 9-2  | 119.6 | +6.5     |
| 4  | LAC  | 6-5  | 118.9 | +5.8     |
| 5  | NYK  | 8-3  | 118.3 | +5.2     |
| 6  | BOS  | 8-3  | 117.7 | +4.6     |
| 7  | MIA  | 7-4  | 117.4 | +4.3     |
| 8  | CLE  | 6-5  | 117.4 | +4.3     |
| 9  | DET  | 6-5  | 117.2 | +4.1     |
| 10 | CHA  | 8-3  | 116.3 | +3.2     |

Table 8: Top 10 defenses over the last 11 games

| Rk | Team | W-L  | DRtg  | Rel DRtg |
|----|------|------|-------|----------|
| 1  | OKC  | 10-1 | 103.0 | -9.9     |
| 2  | ATL  | 11-0 | 103.0 | -9.8     |
| 3  | NYK  | 8-3  | 106.3 | -6.6     |
| 4  | CHA  | 8-3  | 106.9 | -6.0     |
| 5  | POR  | 6-5  | 108.0 | -4.9     |
| 6  | BOS  | 8-3  | 108.6 | -4.3     |
| 7  | SAS  | 9-2  | 108.6 | -4.2     |
| 8  | DET  | 6-5  | 109.1 | -3.7     |
| 9  | ORL  | 7-4  | 109.7 | -3.1     |
| 10 | LAL  | 10-1 | 110.0 | -2.9     |

Table 9: Top 10 net ratings over the last 11 games

| Rk | Team | W-L  | NetRtg | Rel Net |
|----|------|------|--------|---------|
| 1  | ATL  | 11-0 | 16.9   | +16.7   |
| 2  | NYK  | 8-3  | 12.0   | +11.8   |
| 3  | SAS  | 9-2  | 11.0   | +10.7   |
| 4  | LAL  | 10-1 | 10.0   | +9.8    |
| 5  | CHA  | 8-3  | 9.4    | +9.2    |
| 6  | BOS  | 8-3  | 9.1    | +8.9    |
| 7  | DET  | 6-5  | 8.0    | +7.8    |
| 8  | OKC  | 10-1 | 8.0    | +7.7    |
| 9  | MIA  | 7-4  | 6.4    | +6.2    |
| 10 | LAC  | 6-5  | 5.1    | +4.8    |

The offense has been elite, the defense has matched it, and the result is the best net rating in the league over this stretch. That's why the margin has been so high.

## Process vs Results

Table 10: Process vs results: which parts of Atlanta's run look sticky and which parts may cool

| Window  | Overall |       |         |      | Offense |       |       | Defense  |          | Efficiency |       |      |
|---------|---------|-------|---------|------|---------|-------|-------|----------|----------|------------|-------|------|
|         | GP      | PPG   | Opp PPG | MOV  | eFG%    | TOV%  | FTr   | Opp eFG% | Opp TOV% | ORtg       | DRtg  | Net  |
| Season  | 69      | 118.1 | 116.6   | 1.5  | 55.1%   | 13.5% | 0.236 | 54.6%    | 15.2%    | 112.6      | 111.3 | 1.3  |
| Last 11 | 11      | 124.0 | 106.2   | 17.8 | 56.5%   | 13.1% | 0.255 | 52.8%    | 16.5%    | 119.9      | 103.0 | 16.9 |

The jump isn't coming from just one area. Atlanta is shooting better, taking care of the ball, getting to the line more, and forcing more turnovers. The offense has improved, jumping about seven points in offensive rating, but the bigger shift is on the other end. Their defensive rating has dropped from 111 to 103, with lower opponent eFG (52.8%) and more forced turnovers (16.5%). That's where the margin is coming from.

## Player Overview (Last 11 Games)

Table 11: Core production over the current 11-game streak

| Player                          | GP | MPG  | PTS  | REB | AST | STL | BLK | FG%   | 3P%   | FT%   | TS%   |
|---------------------------------|----|------|------|-----|-----|-----|-----|-------|-------|-------|-------|
| <b>Dyson Daniels</b>            | 11 | 31.5 | 11.5 | 7.8 | 5.8 | 2.4 | 0.5 | 58.4% | 12.5% | 63.6% | 60.0% |
| <b>Jalen Johnson</b>            | 11 | 33.2 | 20.2 | 9.6 | 8.2 | 1.2 | 0.3 | 46.2% | 37.0% | 76.1% | 54.3% |
| <b>Nickeil Alexander-Walker</b> | 11 | 33.4 | 22.3 | 2.7 | 3.5 | 1.7 | 0.3 | 51.9% | 48.3% | 97.4% | 69.9% |
| <b>Onyeka Okongwu</b>           | 11 | 29.5 | 13.7 | 8.5 | 3.4 | 1.1 | 1.5 | 47.5% | 37.5% | 72.0% | 58.5% |

### Nickeil Alexander-Walker

Alexander-Walker has been playing the best basketball of his career over this stretch. The scoring stands out, but it's the efficiency that matters. He's shooting nearly 52% from the field and 48% from three while putting up over 22 a night. Everything has been going down, from pull-ups to catch-and-shoot looks to tough shots late in the clock, and he's doing it without forcing the game. He's also held up on the other end. He's been active, competing, and not giving anything away defensively, even if it's not quite at his peak level.

### Jalen Johnson

Johnson has been the engine of this run, even if the efficiency hasn't fully been there. He's around 20, 10, and 8, and a lot of what Atlanta is doing runs through him. He's grabbing and going, pushing pace, and creating without stopping the flow. The shots haven't always fallen, but the impact is still there.

### Dyson Daniels

Daniels is the swing piece in all of this. The shooting is rough, there's no way around it, but everything else is elite. He gets downhill, makes the right pass, cuts at the right time, and finds ways to finish

even without a jumper. Most importantly, he maximizes possessions. The steals, the deflections, the extra chances he creates, it all adds up. He's everywhere, and it's a big reason this has worked.

## Onyeka Okongwu

Okongwu has been a big part of this run, and the shooting is the story. He's turned into a legitimate stretch big, knocking down threes and forcing defenses to treat him differently. That changes the spacing for everything else Atlanta wants to do. He's still giving them around 14 and 8, finishing plays and holding up defensively. Not an elite rim protector, but solid, even when he's asked to do a lot.

## The Core Makes More Sense

The most encouraging part of this run is how cleanly the roles fit. Alexander-Walker has given them efficient perimeter scoring without taking over the offense. Johnson has handled the bulk of the creation, rebounding, and pace. Daniels has filled in everything else, defending, rebounding, and connecting possessions.

## Remaining Concerns

There are still reasons to stay measured. The full season has been uneven, and some of the offense is being boosted by shooting that won't fully hold. The upcoming stretch should test this version more seriously. Better teams, tighter games, less margin for error.

Table 12: Remaining Strength of Schedule Context

| Rank     | Team       | SOS          | Games Left | Toughest Opponents                        | Easiest Opponents          |
|----------|------------|--------------|------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| 1        | MEM        | 0.555        | 14         | SAS, BOS, NYK, CLE(2), DEN                | UTA, CHI, MIL              |
| 2        | IND        | 0.551        | 12         | SAS, DET, LAL, CLE, MIN, ORL              | BKN, CHI, WAS              |
| 3        | NOP        | 0.548        | 11         | DET, BOS, NYK, CLE, MIN, HOU              | SAC, UTA, POR              |
| 4        | UTA        | 0.538        | 12         | OKC, LAL, CLE, HOU, DEN, TOR              | WAS, NOP, MEM              |
| 5        | DAL        | 0.538        | 12         | SAS, LAL, MIN, DEN, PHX, ORL              | CHI, MIL, GSW, POR, LAC(2) |
| 6        | OKC        | 0.536        | 12         | DET, BOS, NYK, LAL, DEN, PHX              | WAS, UTA, CHI, LAC         |
| <b>7</b> | <b>ATL</b> | <b>0.536</b> | <b>13</b>  | <b>DET, BOS(2), NYK(2), CLE, HOU, ORL</b> | <b>BKN, SAC, MEM, GSW</b>  |
| 8        | BOS        | 0.535        | 13         | OKC, NYK, MIN, TOR, ORL, ATL(2)           | MEM, CHA, MIL              |

## Final Thoughts

It's still March, so this isn't the time to declare anything solved. Some regression is coming, and the full season still matters. But that shouldn't take away from what's actually happened. Atlanta has won 11 straight, gone 14–6 over their last 20, and done it in a way that looks different from earlier in the year.

This team has gelled at the right time. The roles are clearer, the production is balanced, and the defense has played at an elite level, supporting the offense instead of relying on it.

Now it gets tested. Atlanta has one of the tougher remaining schedules in the league, with multiple games against teams at the top of the East. This next stretch should tell us whether this is just a run or something they can carry forward.

If it holds, the conversation shifts to what this core actually is, and what it could look like over the coming years.